inert materials are used for coating the somatic embryoids like agrose and sodium alginate.

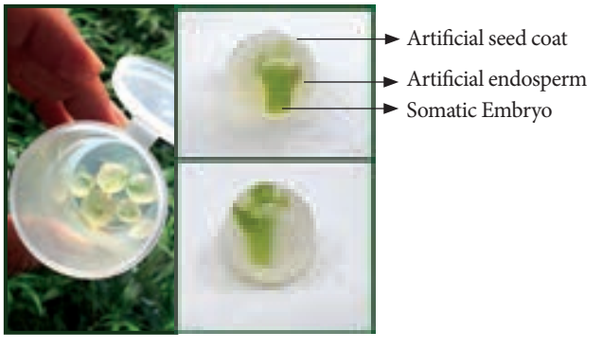


Figure 5.12: Artificial seeds

Advantages of Artificial seeds

Artificial seeds have many advantages over the true seeds

- Millions of artificial seeds can be produced at any time at low cost.
- They provide an easy method to produce genetically engineered plants with desirable traits.
- It is easy to test the genotype of plants.
- They can potentially stored for long time under cryopreservation method.
- Artificial seeds produce identical plants
- The period of dormancy of artificial seeds is greatly reduced, hence growth is faster with a shortened life cycle.

5.5.3 Virus-free plants

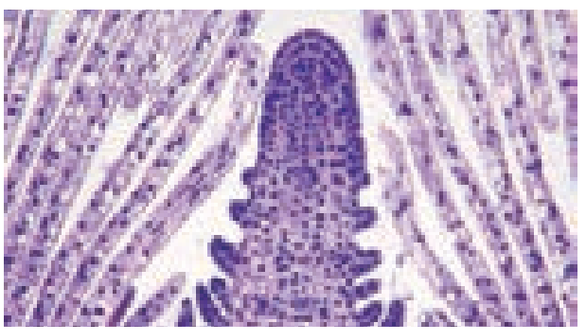


Figure 5.13: Shoot tip - Apical Meristem

The field grown plants like perennial crops, usually are infected by variety of pathogens like fungi, bacteria, mycoplasma, viruses which cause considerable economic losses. Chemical methods can be used to control fungal and bacterial pathogens, but not viruses generally.

Shoot meristem tip culture is the method to produce virus-free plants, because the shoot meristem tip is always free from viruses.

5.6 Conservation of plant genetic resources

5.6.1 Germplasm Conservation

Germplasm conservation refers to the conservation of living genetic resources like pollen, seeds or tissue of plant material maintained for the purpose of selective plant breeding, preservation in live condition and used for many research works.

Germplasm conservation resources is a part of collection of seeds and pollen that are stored in seed or pollen banks, so as to maintain their viability and fertility for any later use such as hybridization and crop improvement. Germplasm conservation may also involve a gene bank, DNA bank of elite breeding lines of plant resources for the maintenance of biological diversity and also for food security.



Figure 5.15: Seed bank

5.6.2 Cryopreservation (–195.C)

Cryopreservation, also known as Cryo-conservation, is a process by which protoplasts, cells, tissues, organelles, organs, extracellular matrix, enzymes or any other biological materials are subjected to preservation by cooling to very low temperature of –196°C using liquid nitrogen. At this extreme low temperature any enzymatic or chemical activity of the biological material will be totally stopped and this leads to preservation of material in dormant status. Later these materials can be activated by bringing to room temperature slowly for any experimental work.



Figure 5.16: Cryopreservation

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